



TICKETS PLEASE

America's largest airline in the early 1930s was United Air Lines, which incorporated four different carriers. As the tickets reproduced above show, it also carried mail.

for example, you would find you were one of four or five passengers in an enclosed cabin, sitting on a cushioned seat with a picture window. You could settle yourself for the flight with a fair expectation of arriving at your destination approximately on schedule. But first-time air travelers were still stunned by the deafening engine noise, and once in the air passengers often found themselves vibrated through an extraordinary fairground ride of bumps and drops as the airplane rode out turbulence. They were always issued with paper airsickness bags on boarding. Cold was also a problem for passengers until heated cabins became the norm – by 1934, an International Air Guide was able to reassure its readers that “no special clothing is required” for flight.

Every effort was made to promote the image of flight as a luxury experience, for it was, after all, suitably expensive. For example, publicity material



IMAGE OF LUXURY

Airline publicity photos, such as this staged image of coffee time on a DC-3, were understandably designed to represent flight as comfortable, even luxurious. They also stressed the presence of women on flights, to counter the popular prejudice that flying was too risky for the “weaker sex.”

emphasized the serving of champagne lunches on some Paris-to-London services. The first in-flight movie was projected during a Luft Hansa flight in 1925 – a silent movie, of course, so the deafening engine noise did not matter. But such refinements were untypical.

The overwhelming majority of European air passengers in the 1920s were male, chiefly government officials or businessmen in a hurry. Many men considered flying too risky for women or children (traditionally categorized together). European airlines in fact killed remarkably few of their customers in those early days, but it would have been an unnerving experience to find your aircraft diving down almost to treetop height to fly under low cloud or carefully sticking to a road or railroad line to avoid getting lost – a practice that led to a fatal collision on the Paris–London route in 1922 between a British and a French aircraft that were following a road in opposite directions. Not surprisingly, flying remained very much a minority experience. By 1929 only 25,000

French citizens had flown as airplane passengers – less than one in a thousand of the population.

The Southern hemisphere

Although Europe was the center of progress in passenger air transportation for most of the 1920s, air travel also prospered in some less populated areas of the world where other forms of transportation were undeveloped. Australia was a good place for air travel because it was mostly flat, had huge distances between towns and an inadequate railroad system, but had plenty of fine weather. The Queensland and Northern Territory Aerial Services Limited (Qantas) was founded in 1920 by two pilots back from the war in Europe, Hudson Fish and Ginty

